没有到来的零日

The Day Zero That Never Came



开普敦怎样避开了水龙头大范围关闭的零日？

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英文原文

In January 2018, Cape Town issued a stark alert: Day Zero could arrive in April. The term denoted a grim threshold, reached when water in the city's reservoirs, as a percentage of capacity, fell to 13.5 per cent. Most taps would then be shut, and residents would queue at about 200 designated collection points.

The prospect was genuine. Three consecutive years of meagre rainfall, from 2015 to 2017, had diminished the reservoirs serving a metropolitan area of about four million people. By early 2018 the dams were roughly a fifth full. The countdown turned a chronic shortage into an imminent deadline.

The city paired mandatory restrictions with unprecedented transparency. From 1 February 2018, each person was allotted 50 litres a day. Officials disclosed dam levels and household consumption; the published tallies made thrift visible and let neighbours benchmark their use. Daily use was more than halved, from about 1.2 billion litres in 2015 to about 500 million by early 2018.

Other forces intervened. In February 2018, upstream farmers released water from their irrigation dams; with farms drawing less, Day Zero was postponed to July. In March 2018, officials judged Day Zero unlikely that year. Winter rains subsequently replenished the reservoirs, which were about half full by July. The 50-litre limit was eased in October 2018.

The burden, critics argued, fell unevenly. Townships, poor areas segregated by race under apartheid, had long made do with scant water, yet steeper tariffs squeezed them hardest. Others blamed alarmist warnings for tourist cancellations. Households, farmers, and rain kept the collection points idle, but the sacrifice weighed heaviest on those with the least to give.

中文译文

2018年1月，开普敦发出严峻警报：“零日”可能在4月到来。这个词指一道令人忧惧的门槛：城市各水库蓄水量降至总容量的13.5%。届时，大多数水龙头将关闭，居民必须到约200个指定取水点排队领水。

这并非虚构的危险。2015至2017年连续三年降雨稀少，为约400万人口的都会区供水的水库蓄水持续下降。到2018年初，蓄水量只剩约五分之一。倒计时把长期缺水变成了一个迫在眉睫的最后期限。

市政府把强制限水与前所未有的信息公开结合起来。从2018年2月1日起，每人每天限用50升水。官员公布水库水位和家庭用水量，让节水成效看得见，也让邻居能相互比较用水情况。全市日用水量已从2015年的约12亿升降至2018年初的约5亿升，减少了一半以上。

其他因素也发挥了作用。2018年2月，上游农民从自有灌溉水库放水，再加上农场减少取水，“零日”被推迟至7月。到了3月，官员判断当年不大可能出现“零日”。随后到来的冬雨补充了水库，到7月时蓄水已恢复至约半满。2018年10月，每人每日50升的限制得到放宽。

批评者指出，负担并不均等。种族隔离时期按种族划出的贫困聚居区，长期以来就只能用少量水勉强生活，却最难承受提高后的水价。也有人指责，危言耸听的警报导致游客取消行程。居民、农民和雨水共同让取水点没有派上用场，但付出最沉重代价的，却是那些最没有余力付出的人。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

issue v.
发出；发布
Cape Town issued a stark alert

stark adj.
严峻鲜明的
a stark alert

denote v.
指；表示
The term denoted a grim threshold

threshold n.
门槛；临界点
a grim threshold

reservoir n.
水库
the city's reservoirs

capacity n.
容量
as a percentage of capacity

designate v.
指定
200 designated collection points

consecutive adj.
连续的
Three consecutive years

meagre adj.
少得可怜的；不足的
meagre rainfall

chronic adj.
长期持续的
a chronic shortage

imminent adj.
迫在眉睫的
an imminent deadline

mandatory adj.
强制性的
mandatory restrictions

unprecedented adj.
前所未有的
unprecedented transparency

transparency n.
公开透明
unprecedented transparency

allot v.
分配；配给
each person was allotted 50 litres

consumption n.
消耗量；用水量
household consumption

benchmark v.
与基准或他人比较
benchmark their use

postpone v.
推迟
Day Zero was postponed to July

replenish v.
补充；重新补给
replenished the reservoirs

burden n.
负担
The burden, critics argued

unevenly adv.
不均等地
fell unevenly

tariff n.
水价；收费标准
steeper tariffs squeezed them hardest

文中词汇与搭配

补充词汇共37项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

alert n.
警报

grim adj.
严酷的；令人忧惧的

percentage n.
百分比

resident n.
居民

prospect n.
可能出现的局面

genuine adj.
真实的；确实存在的

diminish v.
减少；使减少

metropolitan adj.
大都市的

dam n.
水坝；此处指水库

roughly adv.
大约

countdown n.
倒计时

shortage n.
短缺

restriction n.
限制措施

litre n.
升

official n.
官员

disclose v.
公布；披露

household n.
家庭

tally n.
统计数目

文中词汇与搭配 续

补充词汇共37项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

thrift n.
节约；节俭

visible adj.
看得见的

halve v.
减半

intervene v.
介入；发挥作用

upstream adj.
上游的

irrigation n.
灌溉

unlikely adj.
不大可能的

subsequently adv.
随后

ease v.
放宽；减轻

township n.
隔离制下的贫困聚居区

segregate v.
按种族隔离

apartheid n.
种族隔离制度

scant adj.
很少的；不足的

steep adj.
价格更高的

squeeze v.
使承受经济压力

alarmist adj.
危言耸听的

cancellation n.
取消；退订

idle adj.
闲置的

sacrifice n.
牺牲；付出的代价

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 The term denoted a grim _____,

02 The city paired _____ restrictions with unprecedented transparency.

03 each person was _____ 50 litres a day.

04 Winter rains subsequently _____ the reservoirs, which were about half full by July.

文章主线

- 危机 连续三年少雨使开普敦水库告急，2018年初当局警告，四月可能迎来零日。
- 门槛 零日指蓄水降至容量的13.5%，届时大部分水龙头关闭，居民须到指定地点领水。
- 节水 日用水量由2015年约12亿升降至2018年初约5亿升；2月起限每人每日50升，并公开水位及用量。
- 转机 居民节水、农场放水及减少取水，使零日一再推迟；随后冬雨补充水库，避免了当年大范围停水。
- 负担 批评者指出，贫困社区原本用水就少，却最难承受上涨水价，节水代价并不均等。

参考答案　1 threshold 2 mandatory 3 allotted 4 replenished